education transcended school lectures and discussions. Her classmates included participants in the student movement whose reactions to repressive U.S. Cold War geopolitical policies and the shadows of Nazi fascism informed Davis's trajectories in academia and activism. In Frankfurt, she lived on Adalbertstrasse with a group of fellow students, several of whom were involved in the Sozialistischer Deutscher Studentbund (Socialist German Student Union, or SDS). With this group she protested the escalating U.S. military aggression in Vietnam and the West German government's complicity in global Cold War conflicts.[3] As U.S. Army bases in West Germany served as gateways of deployment for soldiers traveling to fight in Vietnam, German universities erupted as flashpoints of protest over the war. They directed their activism toward confronting the legacy of fascism and practices of repressive governance in West Germany. These student activists drew inspiration from the civil rights, Black Power, and Free Speech movements in the United States, as well as the international struggles for decolonization. Davis studied and organized alongside fellow international students, including at least one black American former GI from Indiana and several who hailed from Haiti and South Africa.[4] While Davis was in West Germany, her graduate education in revolutionary philosophical theory fueled a critical praxis, linking her intellectual pursuits with her activism. At the same time, she was constantly reminded of her distance from black freedom struggles back home.

Davis's intellectual life and activist engagements in West Germany crystallized during one short trip to Cold War Berlin during her first spring semester of graduate school. She traveled to Cold War Berlin in the spring of 1966, with other students from her scholarship program, for a conference held by the German Academic Exchange Service, otherwise known as the DAAD.[5] By design, her school group visited West Berlin for a conference supported by a state-operated program of exchange; by choice, Davis largely separated from her group, crossing the city's border to visit East Berlin during the city's May Day festivities nourished by this alternate circuit of diplomacy. She passed crowds of Western tourists at the observation decks near the Wall at Checkpoint Charlie, leaving them behind to be able to experience a bit of her hometown of Birmingham in East Berlin. There, Davis visited her parents' friends Esther and James E. Jackson, prominent African American activists, and Robert Lumer, the stepbrother of her childhood friends Margaret and Claudia Burnham. The Jacksons, who had